

Brand systems beyond the logo

Week 8, Lecture 2, Design for Builders: Ship Beautiful Products as a Founder

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Voice and tone: how your brand sounds across every surface
- Brand colors vs UI colors: the distinction most builder-brands miss
- Photography and illustration style: the visual language that surrounds the logo
- The one-page brand sheet: what goes on it and how to build it in Figma

Part 1: voice and tone

What voice is

Brand voice is the consistent personality of your product across every word it produces: marketing copy, onboarding emails, error messages, button labels.

Tone is how that voice shifts by context. The same brand can be:

- Encouraging in onboarding
- Direct in error messages
- Warmer in billing confirmations

Voice is fixed. Tone adjusts (How to Build a Brand Guidelines System in Figma 2024).

A brand without a defined voice is a brand that sounds different every time a different person writes something for it.

Why voice belongs on the brand sheet

Most builder-made brand sheets stop at the logo and color palette. Voice is almost always missing.

The result: the logo and product visuals say “modern, professional, trusted” while the copy says “Hey there! Looks like something went wrong.”

Voice is the layer of brand identity that compounds fastest with user perception. Every sentence is a micro-touchpoint. Two hundred inconsistent micro-touchpoints add up to a brand that feels incoherent, even when the visuals are polished.

Building a simple voice guide

Three components fit on a single page:

1. **Three to five voice adjectives**, the personality in plain language (“direct, warm, precise”)
2. **Three “we say / we don’t say” pairs**, concrete examples of the voice in action and its opposite
3. **One example paragraph**, a short piece of copy that demonstrates the voice, not just names it

That is enough to align a contractor, a new hire, or a future version of yourself three months from now.

Part 2: brand colors vs UI colors

The color separation most builders skip

A product has two distinct color systems:

- **Brand colors**, the colors that express identity: used in marketing, the logo, the brand sheet, print materials
- **UI colors**, the colors that drive interaction: used in components, states, tokens, the product interface

These overlap but they are not the same (Chris Do, The Futur 2022).

The most common mistake: using the saturated brand primary as the default button color in the product. That color was chosen for impact in a marketing context, not for legibility, accessibility, or repeated-use fatigue.

What goes wrong when you conflate them

A brand primary that is a vivid orange at 100% saturation:

- Passes WCAG AA at large sizes but fails at 14px body text
- Creates visual tension when every interactive element on the screen competes for attention with the brand color
- Exhausts the brand association: seeing it 200 times per session strips it of the resonance it has in a hero section

The fix: derive a functional color from the brand color, not a copy.

Pull the brand hue, reduce the saturation, adjust the lightness to pass contrast. Use that for buttons. Reserve the full saturation for the logo and marketing contexts.

The two-palette model

	Brand palette	UI palette
Purpose	Identity, marketing, brand recognition	Interaction, feedback, hierarchy
Source	Designer intuition + brand adjectives	Brand palette + accessibility requirements
Primary use	Logo, hero sections, print	Buttons, links, tokens
Saturation	High, chosen for impact	Lower, chosen for usability

Both palettes reference the same hue family. They are not independent.

Part 3: photography and illustration

Why visual style is part of brand identity

The logo is on roughly four surfaces: the website header, the app icon, the favicon, and the OG image. Photography and illustration are on every other surface.

A product's visual style is mostly determined by the images it uses, not by the logo.

A brand with a warm humanist wordmark that uses cold, high-contrast stock photography has a contradictory identity. The wordmark says one thing. The imagery says another (How to Build a Brand Guidelines System in Figma 2024).

Photography style: four axes to define

Define your photography style on four axes. You do not need to write paragraphs. You need to pick a position:

- **Subjects:** people in context vs abstract objects vs data/illustration vs no photography
- **Lighting:** natural and warm vs studio and clean vs dark and dramatic
- **Color treatment:** desaturated and cool vs saturated and warm vs processed (muted, faded, high-contrast)
- **Staging:** candid/documentary vs composed and styled vs product-only

One sentence per axis. That gives any contributor enough constraint to find appropriate images.

Illustration: when to use it

Illustration is a choice, not a default. Use it when:

- The product concept is abstract and photography cannot make it concrete
- The brand voice is playful and a photorealistic style conflicts with that voice
- The onboarding empty states benefit from a character or a visual metaphor

Illustration requires consistency across the library. One style must cover: icons, empty states, error states, marketing headers.

The most common mistake: using four different illustrators across four sections of the product. The style variance reads as incoherence rather than variety.

Part 4: the one-page brand sheet

What the brand sheet is for

A **brand sheet** is a single Figma frame that gives any contributor everything they need to work with the brand correctly.

It is not a 40-page brand guidelines document. It is one page.

The audience for the brand sheet is:

- A contractor who needs to build a marketing page
- A future co-founder who needs to give a press kit image
- You, six months from now, when you cannot remember which shade of blue was the primary

The five sections of a one-page brand sheet

1. **Logo lockups**, horizontal, stacked, and icon-only in dark and light versions
2. **Color palette**, brand primary and its ramp, neutrals, accent if any, with hex and OKLCH values
3. **Typography**, the two typefaces, the scale, with a live specimen of the headline and body styles
4. **Image direction**, three photography or illustration examples with one sentence of guidance
5. **Voice summary**, three adjectives, three “we say / we don’t say” pairs, one example sentence

One frame in Figma. Exportable as a PNG. Shareable as a link. This is the brand sheet (How to Build a Brand Guidelines System in Figma 2024).

How to build it in Figma

Use one top-level auto-layout frame, vertical direction, with consistent internal padding.

Each section is its own nested frame:

- The logo section: place each lockup variant with labeled minimum-size notes below
- The color section: swatches built as component instances from your Week 4 variable collection
- The type section: live text samples connected to your Week 3 text styles
- The image direction: three imported images at the same size, captioned
- The voice section: a table component or a set of text layers

Everything should reference tokens and styles already defined in your file. If you find yourself hardcoding a hex value on the brand sheet, something is out of sync.

The brand sheet is the assignment

HW4 asks you to produce this brand sheet for your own product.

It is not a design exercise for a fictional product. It is a production asset for yours.

At the end of Week 9, when you are building marketing assets (App Store screenshots, OG images, favicons), the brand sheet is the source of truth you reference. If you did not make it explicit this week, you will make decisions inconsistently next week.

The brand sheet is not overhead. It is the work.

Take-aways

1. Voice and tone belong on the brand sheet. A polished logo paired with inconsistent copy is a contradictory brand identity.
2. Brand colors and UI colors are different systems derived from the same hue. The brand primary is often too saturated to be the button color.
3. Photography and illustration style determine most of the visual identity. Define yours on four axes: subjects, lighting, color treatment, and staging.
4. A one-page brand sheet covers five sections: logo lockups, color, typography, image direction, voice.
5. The brand sheet should reference tokens and styles already in your Figma file. Hardcoded values are a sign of drift.

"Your brand is not your logo. Your brand is what people say about you when you're not in the room."

Chris Do, The Futur, "The Power of Design: Chris Do on Brand Logos," 2022

What's next

- **This week, section:** Logo studio, three wordmark drafts, peer critique, and a written selection rationale
- **Week 9:** Marketing assets: App Store screenshots, OG images, favicons, and legal asset sources
- **Reading:** Week 8 reading at </c/design-for-builders-26au/readings/wk08>
- **HW4 out:** Brand sheet for your product, due Week 9

